‘That was expected. You stick around. Let me know if you get something worthwhile.’

Bobb hung up.

He had sounded very polite, just the opposite of how he had been seconds ago to whoever he was shouting at in office. What a relief! Anirudhya picked up the TV remote and paused at CNN. He thought of having a drink. He had saved a hundred from his first day’s allowance. The room service menu suggested not even a pint of beer would come in that amount. He took a shower and hit the bed.

The phone rang. It was from the office of IG R.K. Raghavan of Tamil Nadu Police. Anirudhya was inside a taxi headed to meet Raghavan in the next five minutes.

Raghavan was waiting for Anirudhya. Even though the SIT had taken over the investigation, Raghavan was as busy as ever. The SIT was new and needed backup and ground support. More than that, Raghavan, in charge of the security arrangements at Rajiv Gandhi’s rally, took it as his moral responsibility to crack the assassination case.

‘We came to know of Rajiv Gandhi’s itinerary in the state on 17 May. Immediately we got down to making the required security arrangements in collaboration with the state and central security agencies,’ Raghavan told Anirudhya.

The latter switched on his tape recorder, hoping Raghavan would not object. But he did. ‘Look, I have nothing to hide. But since the CBI has taken over the investigation, it won’t be fair on my part to comment on the case officially,’ he said. The tape recorder was put back in its place.

Raghavan resumed talking. His office had issued instructions on 20 May to ensure there would be crowd and access control at the venue. Senior officers were deputed to coordinate with the organizers of the meeting, mostly from the Congress party, to prepare a list of VVIP guests to be allowed for a ‘meet and greet’ with Rajiv Gandhi. Metal detectors were sanctioned to screen them. More than 300 police personnel were stationed there that night to guard the red carpet area and keep an eye on guests. But, most unfortunately, the female police who were assigned the task of